



“Our support system for working women who want to or have children is broken. Nuclear families are now more prevalent”

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their most pressing workplace challenges.

As *Business Today* celebrates the 21st edition of the Most Powerful Women in Business (MPW), highlighting the lives of women leaders who have made a difference across organisations between September 2023 and September 2024, it is all the more crucial and serves as an inspiration to other women who have just begun their professional journeys.

DRIVING CHANGE

However, experts and industry leaders believe that there are some winds of change and the government, organisations as well as individuals are working to change these biases and perceptions and effect a real change on the ground, be it in terms of assignments and roles, pay and rewards or infrastructure.

Anjali Raghuvanshi, Chief People Officer and Senior Director-

Business Innovation at talent company Randstad India, says that there has been greater participation of women in corporate India. “At the mid-level and above, roles are becoming more gender neutral. There may be some perceptions still at the entry level but less and less people now believe that, say, an HR role or an executive assistant role has to go to a woman. Women are also opting for more business-facing roles. That’s a welcome change,” she highlights.

While laws are already in place to prevent gender discrimination in employment or wages, organisations are also now working to not only encourage but also incentivise and retain women employees as they realise that supporting a woman employee works to their advantage. “If an organisation stands with a woman employee in the time of her need, she will stay with them for a longer run and give more in return,” underlines Raghuvanshi.

This is not all. The NCAER study also found positive correlations between having women in leadership positions and the firm’s culture. “We find that having at least one woman on [the] board is associated with higher economic performance, financial stability, and lower financial risk for the larger firms. We observe that although all firms see some impact on financial performance after hiring at least one woman following the mandate, mid-cap and large-cap firms see a more consistent impact for a longer period post-mandate,” said the study.

It also found that a higher share of women in board positions is positively associated with employee ratings and sentiment scores, but the relationship is significant only when there is at least one woman in a top management (C-suite) position.

Organisations are now offering options such as remote working and flexible hours for women employees